Observation Notes from UConn Childhood Labs

Classroom Notes

10/13/25

- Play Blocks
- Teachers playing with children
- Children are playing in parallel, not together
- Sensory toys --> make sounds and stick to surfaces
- Teachers show how to engage with toys to children
- Children are able to count toys
- Toys are relatively small, handheld
- Variety of colors, are modular (different configurations)
- Children appear to try to make different configurations
- One child is sleeping nearby
- Group of children are playing on a table
- Another group is playing with different toys nearby
- Children Group A are counting together
- Group B are playing on rug cooperatively
- Layout: Classroom set up, rug with tables and shelves nearby
- Children gather for snack
- Group A appears to play cooperatively with modular toys
- Transition into snack time and next activity
- Group C are playing with a collection of leaves crafts
- Generally playing parallel, but communication amongst eachother
- Children in Group C are exploring with how they can modify the leaves with the toys
- Children Group D are “pretending” to cook food on a stove
- Parallel play – children are each making their own foods (pizza, tortillas, cookies)
- Toys
    - Wooden stove on table
    - Wooden/plastic food
- One child is playing with a toy hammer for a bit
- No formally given roleplay roles
- Children Group E are stacking blocks on floor next to mirror (cardboard)
- Generally playing parallel and cooperative in some instances
- Updates
    - Pretend cooking has decreased to 2 children from 5 in a span of 10 minutes
    - Majority are playing with stacking blocks
    - Child 1 states that there is no objective --> now a house

    - Group F2 are climbing up a tower
    - Appear to be playing parallel / cooperatively with plush animals on the top of tower
    - Appear to be laying down on plush surface while playing
    - Shrieking in joy/excitement
    - Group E are assigning teacher roles for a pretend play classroom

10/15/25

Classroom 1

- Group A is playing with small blocks parallel playing, but are interacting/engaging in conversation
- Group B is playing with larger wooden blocks parallel
- Conservations: "Can I use this on mine?"
- Some issues with conflict resolution
    - Sharing toys
    - Accepting someone in a group who wants to play
- One child was playing unsafely with wooden blocks, stacking too high (according to teacher)
- All kids playing in class playing with blocks
- One child asks who wants to play a game they have in mind first (assumes group activity/social play)
- Children playing with wood blocks are playing socially
- Group C are playing with smaller pretend play hammers, playing solitary
- Group B is continuing to play with blocks with game in mind (has not started)
- Children talk about superpowers

Classroom 2

- Snacktime upon arrival for some children
- One child is scooping fake icecream from a sandbox with caretaker present
    - Using pretend play scooper
- Group A is around a table talking about icecream flavors/shorbet
- All children gather around to play near sandbox scooping icecream with caretaker, parallel playing
- Issue with conflict resolutions, tolerating different preferences on icecream flavors
- Mostly playing parallel with eachother, socially with caretakers
- Group C are looking at hermit crab in tank

- Group D are playing with plastic animals with caretaker
- Group E are playing wooden blocks socially
- Mostly parallel play throughout duration

Interview Notes from Julie Borstrom – Preschool Director @ The Childrens Museum in West Hartford CT 10/20/25 1:00PM

- Parallel play for most part --> depends on feelings of children
- Dramatic lay encourages social play
- Book, puzzles solitary play
- Fidgeting toys for those with sensory issues
- Not many kids with disabilities, toys and play centers are for most part not inclusive
- 10 kids , 2 teachers
- Issue: Only so many kids at one time at a pretend play center
- Every 2 weeks themes change – theme buckets
- Movie theater set
- Centers that emulate real life settings
- Always kitchen in dramatic play
- Pizza shop – empty pizza boxes, play cups, photocopy money
- Kids also have a role in designing play sets – making menus
- Some themes are not best for both genders (color, themes)
- Roleplay / costumes included in playsets
- Conflict resolutions – timer for turn taking, notes for turn taking, take away toys
- Themes Favorites: Princess, Superheroes, Dressup, Trains, Restaurants, true to life, Ice-cream Shop, Movie Theater
- Dance parties
- Interactivity

Questions For Julie Bostrom

2. Environment & Daily Interaction

- How do preschoolers typically use the furniture and play elements in your classrooms?
- Are there specific pieces or setups that children are especially drawn to or use creatively?
- What design features like height, color, shape, or flexibility seem to make the biggest difference in how children engage?

3. Developmental & Behavioral Insights

- From your experience, what types of spaces or activities best encourage social play, focus, or creativity?
- Are there common frustrations you see when children interact with furniture or toys (for example: stability, accessibility, overstimulation)?
- How does the physical environment influence children's behavior, comfort, or transitions during the day?

4. Safety, Maintenance & Practical Factors

- What are the most critical safety factors you consider when introducing new items into the classroom?
- How do cleaning, maintenance, or durability affect what products you choose to keep long-term?
- Have there been materials or forms you've learned to avoid over the years?

5. Inclusivity & Adaptability

- How do you adapt classroom environments for children with different physical or sensory needs?
- Have you seen effective examples of furniture or play designs that support inclusivity or comfort for all children?

Interview Notes from Mary Nurmec: Connecticut Children's Foundation 10/14/25

- Medical Play, pretend play
- Examples: Lego set, Pretend play MRI Machine
- Bradies Buggies
    - Wagon for IV pool for kid --> specifically made for kid
    - Tray table
    - Adjustable pillow
    - Cup holder
- ButterflyPig Website
- 3D print medical devices – pretend play
- Hospital also has pretend play CAT scanner + other medical devices
- Play
    - Kid directly plays with specialist
    - Tricycle that's modified to hold IV pool for patients that have to carry it
    - Powerwheel for patients about to undergo medical procedures

- Consider developmental age for toys
- Adjusting features for calm environment
- Pretend Play Dolls that have medical devices on them (IV drips, etc)
    - Medkin Dolls for chemotherapy patients
    - Some companies offered specialized dolls that are modified according to the patient's condition
- Play groups offered, mostly parallel/solitary play
- Photos below from Mary Nurmec

Moana
NG Kit
Mitrofanoff Teach